

have a stellar session

The date is quickly approaching: your important meeting or presentation is imminent!

This is a great point to reflect back on the various steps we've taken to get here. It all started with the planning: understanding your audience, carefully crafting your message, compiling the pieces, and then weaving it all together into a story. You created your content: first setting the style and structure of your presentation, and then filling in the specifics—thoughtfully designing slides with words, graphs, and images. As part of your preparations to deliver, you refined your content and spoken words through practice, built your confidence, and learned the art of the introduction.

We have invested a great deal of energy readying you for this. And now, *you are ready*. I have a few final tips to share: strategies to use in the days leading up to your session and in the moments before, during, and after. But more than anything, I encourage you to be fully present and enjoy yourself. You've put in a tremendous amount of effort. Now is when all of that hard work pays off.

It is time to engage people and inspire the action that you seek.

Final prep: the days leading up to your session

When you first started thinking about this project, it's possible you were facing months or weeks before your final presentation. Perhaps you've been working on it a little at a time over a long period, or maybe you've been in crunch mode trying to get everything quickly finished. Irrespective of how much time you've spent: you'll reach the point where only days (or hours!) remain between you and your session.

Envision success

Reflect on your primary goals for your meeting or presentation: what precisely do you hope to achieve? Think about success from a couple of perspectives. First, consider what you hope *for your audience*. How do you want them to feel, what do you expect to have happen, and what action should they take?

Recognize that even if people respond differently than you wish, that won't necessarily indicate that you were unsuccessful. Perhaps your audience will decide—in light of what you share or because of the insightful discussion you prompt—that another course of action is warranted. This would still be a great outcome.

Also think about success in terms of *yourself*. What do you want to experience before, during, and after your session? Given all that you've learned as you've practiced and prepared, are there things you hope to actively do or avoid?

Write down a few goals that you would like to accomplish. I'll ask you to refer back to this after you present. Your personal expectations in particular are worth recording: how you measure and judge your own success presenting in meetings, standing on stage, and in other presentation settings will change over time. Devote a journal to document your journey to storyteller, and observe your progress firsthand as you become increasingly effective.

Now that you've spent some time in self-reflection, let's figure out how to involve others.

Don't go at it alone

You may be the one responsible for some or all of the presentation, but that doesn't mean you have to do it on your own. Consider where and how you might get support from others. This can take a variety of forms; I'll list a few below.

- **Plant a friendly face in the audience.** Have a friend or your spouse attend your keynote address and sit where you are able to see them. Invite your manager to be present at your important meeting. In a virtual setting, ask a supportive colleague to join and organize your screen so they are in clear view. It's amazing what positive reinforcement a slight nod or smile from a friendly face lends while presenting.
- **Identify or develop a supporter.** Meet with select stakeholders individually ahead of time. Then you'll know who is in your court during the session. Alternatively, if someone is not supportive, meeting with them can help you better understand any resistance and work to resolve it ahead of time. In a conference setting, accomplish this through interactions with participants before your session begins.
- **Enlist a co-presenter or helper.** Line someone up to assist with the actual presentation or meeting. This could be a moderator for Q&A, an official co-presenter who will cover parts of the planned content, or someone you prep to weigh in or be ready to ask or address certain questions or discussion topics. In a virtual setting, particularly if participants can interact in various ways, it is often useful to recruit a colleague to help manage chat or lend a voice to the questions that get posed there.
- **Line someone up to give you feedback.** Identify someone who will be in attendance to offer their input afterwards (this can be someone you've also selected to play one of the previous roles described). Let them know your specific goals ahead of time. The simple act of asking for their assessment will have them rooting for you during your presentation.

Virtual setting: post a motivating picture

Sometimes even when you have supporters in the virtual environment, it's impossible to tell because either the faces on your screen are too small or you can't see your audience at all. As a substitute, post a picture of someone you'd like to make proud in your line of sight to offer encouragement in absentia: your child, parent, partner, or friend. This can both help remind you that you are speaking to people (not a computer screen) and help you feel encouraged while you do.

Before closing your eyes on the eve of your event...

Setting yourself up for success starts much earlier than twenty-four hours before an important session. That said, there are things you can do on that final day—especially during the evening—directly prior to your presentation that will have a positive impact.

Do everything in your power to ensure good, restorative rest. I recommend eating an early dinner and avoiding sugar, caffeine, and alcohol. Eating two to three hours before bedtime can drastically improve your sleep. When we eat late, it means that the muscles that digest and metabolize our food have to keep working when they could be resting. This has a negative impact on your ability to fall asleep and prevents you from getting the deep sleep you require to feel refreshed the next day.

Use some of the time between dinner and bedtime to review your materials. Before an important presentation, my routine is to have my slides be the last thing I look at before going to sleep. I advance through them on my laptop to make sure I'm clear on order and flow. I'll review my notes to myself as well: reminders on filler words to avoid, how I plan to move, and anything else I want to have top of mind for my session. I like to think (and there's some

research to back it up) that this practice helps important points move from my short-term memory to my long-term memory overnight.

This is not the time to be working on your content! I recognize that sometimes it's unavoidable: you had a less-than-ideal amount of time to get it all done and simply have to finish the deck. Even in that instance (and especially in the one where your materials are already sufficient): spend as little additional time as possible. The hours that separate you from your meeting or presentation should be focused on *you*—ensuring you'll have the energy to present powerfully—not continued tweaks or minor improvements to your slides.

Get to bed early. Also set your alarm to ensure you have ample time before your session, because there are a few things I'll suggest you do during the minutes before your presentation as well. Speaking of time, plan to wear a watch tomorrow—you're going to need it!

Wear a watch

It will be important to monitor the time leading up to and during your session. Unless you're certain there will be an easily visible clock, I highly recommend wearing a watch. A quick glance at your wrist is an unobtrusive way to check the time. Don't rely on your phone for this—you don't want to inadvertently give the impression that the possibility of an incoming text or email is more important than your audience!

Take a deep breath: it's about to start!

On the day of your session, I have a single piece of advice: arrive early. The flex time this provides can be used in a number of ways to help ensure things go well.

Arrive early

If you are able to get into the room where you'll present ahead of time, do it. Set up your equipment and assess whether there are other things to be done. I've been known to rearrange furniture—pulling a podium out of the way or situating tables or chairs to better facilitate discussion.

While I don't prefer to use a podium, I do want somewhere to set my water, coffee or tea, and notebook, so I'll work out the best place to do that. On that note, I'll also make sure I have said beverages (personally, I opt for coffee in the morning, tea in the afternoon, and always have water on hand). In a meeting room, I'll simply bring them with me and place them somewhere I can access. When presenting formally from a stage, sometimes you have the option to stash them in a podium. At an event with multiple speakers, often organizers will have bottled water available on stage.

Eat before you present—but not too much!

To keep your energy up, I recommend eating something light an hour or two before your important meeting or presentation. As was the case with spacing your dinner before sleep, it's important to allow some time between your pre-session meal and the session itself so you can direct all of your faculties to your presentation.

Depending on the length, you may need to eat during your session as well. This won't be necessary in shorter presentations (I'd avoid it to preserve professionalism). During longer sessions—for instance, a half-day

offsite or a full-day training—you should eat to maintain stamina. But not too much! Eating a large or heavy meal makes you feel sluggish. I also find that even after a small lunch during the all-day workshops that I teach, I have trouble fully catching my breath. This is the result of some of my body's attention being put toward digestion. To counter this, I've reworked post-lunch content to start with a group discussion, giving my body a little extra time before I have to be fully on again.

Walk all the way around the room to gain perspective and plot where to stand and how to move about the space if you didn't have the opportunity ahead of time. In an ideal world, you will have already run through your slides in the given venue. If that *didn't* happen and it's possible now, quickly take advantage of it (if attendees are already present, I'd suggest skipping it to avoid inadvertently starting a premature discussion).

If there is a mobile whiteboard or flipchart that you plan to draw on, move it to where you want it. When I intend to present mainly from the front of the room (and if people are generally facing frontward), I tend to opt for side-of-the-room placement if the physical space allows for it. I'll position it in the back or where I can best minimize the number of people who have to turn to see it if the audience is seated around one large table. These arrangements give me a reason and reminder to move to different parts of the room as I present or guide discussion. Use this also as an opportunity to test markers and eliminate any that might fail you when you go to emphasize a point or draw an example.

Ideally, all of this last-minute prep happens before others arrive. Once attendees begin filing into the room, chat with them. This is a great opportunity. If you already know individuals, the interaction with friendly faces can help calm nerves or give you fodder to draw on if it makes sense during the session. Introduce yourself to those with whom you aren't familiar. Work to remember or write down names if that makes sense given your scenario (acknowledging

individuals by name is an excellent way to establish rapport during the session). Use the informal time to build support and create advocates by connecting with the individuals who will comprise your audience.

Seed what you need

If there's something you will expect from an attendee, use the time before the session begins to give them a heads up. This might include if you want someone to volunteer a specific answer in response to a question, express immediate support for a position you raise, be prepared to address a certain topic, or participate in other ways. The ahead-of-time prep helps you avoid an awkward pause or unexpected response.

Take a quiet moment

Before things officially start, take a quiet moment for yourself. In a formal presentation setting, you may already have a dedicated area for this: backstage or in a green room. If not, locate a private space. I've been known to wander and find an empty conference room or office for this. If all else fails, there's always the restroom. Use this time to ground yourself.

What this looks like exactly will vary from person to person. I encourage you to establish your own routine that works for you. If you're not sure what that entails, here are some ideas.

- **Assume a power pose.** Put both hands on your hips with your shoulders back and smile. Or if you have ample space, put your arms out behind you like you're Superwoman (or Superman) flying through the air. Yes, this

sounds super silly. Yes, I've totally done it in the bathroom stall before going on stage at an important event.

- **Breathe deeply.** Take a long, deep breath in through your nose with your shoulders relaxed. Exhale slowly through your mouth, pursing your lips slightly (so it's audible) but with your jaw relaxed. Repeat several times.
- **Put things into perspective.** Look at a photo of your family, pet, or something else that brings you joy. Use it to remind yourself that this single event likely won't make or break you and that there are more important things in life.

Get ready to have some fun—it's showtime!

Have a knockout meeting or presentation

You know your stuff incredibly well. Many of the specifics of what you'll say and do live were explored deeply through the practice you undertook in Chapters 9, 10, and 11. Your job while presenting is to let all of that go—you don't have to actively think about it, because it's still in your mind and muscle memory. Simply concentrate on doing your best, connecting with people, and responding with grace to whatever comes your way.

Be in the moment

Work to stay fully present. This means fighting any urge to rush immediately into your content. Take a moment to actively notice where you are and who is around you. Breathe deeply. Smile.

You know how you're going to start because you planned and practiced it. As you progress through your content, continue to observe. This may mean pausing to invite input, interaction, or discussion or to make a quick note about something you don't want to forget if appropriate.

Nerves got the better of you? Pause and reset

I promised you that your planned start would carry you beyond your nerves. However, if this doesn't happen, all is not lost. In the situation where you find you're going too fast, having a hard time breathing, and your voice is quivering: stop. Pause. Take a drink of water. Breathe deeply to reset. Yes, it's a little awkward to do this in front of others, but it's much better to take this moment and recover from it to deliver a great presentation than to continue in a stressed-out state. The latter makes everyone uncomfortable. The former shows you're human and can even endear you to those in attendance, who may develop a heightened sense of your poise (once you regain it).

If you have a set amount of time on the meeting agenda or designated start and ends, you'll also need to keep an eye on the clock. In some scenarios, you may rely on the timing sheet you developed during your dry run. Use it to assess where you are in your content and understand whether it means making adjustments in the moment. In other cases, you're simply going to have to be aware of how long different segments are taking and move things along appropriately. Stick to your predetermined or planned time; this shows that you respect your audience.

Aren't you glad you wore that watch I suggested?

While you keep an eye on the clock, you'll also want to pay attention to others in the room. Observing reactions is a great way to gauge how things are going. Responding thoughtfully to what you see is a fantastic way to ensure things go well.

Watch and adjust

When presenting, make sure you are talking to the people in the room—not your slides. Make eye contact. When you know your content well, you can more easily observe audience cues and take action.

When you look at others in the room as you're presenting, what do you see?

Smiles and nods are positive signals that likely indicate what you're saying and how you're saying it are landing well. But what about when brows are furrowed and lips are pursed? Sometimes, people simply look that way when they are absorbing information—but it may also be a sign that they are confused about or in disagreement with something you've said. In some instances, it might make sense to pause and dig into that. Do it directly ("Chris, I think I see confusion on your face: what questions do you have?") or generally ("I think I'm observing disagreement in the room. Who can help me understand it?").

Blinded by the light

There are times—presenting formally from a stage, lights bearing down and in your face—that you can't see your audience at all. This is a challenge. In some instances, it's possible to still view those seated near the front. Use them as your visual cues to assess how things are going, but continue to look out into the audience or others will feel ignored. If you can't see anyone at all, it's similar to presenting virtually. When this happens, I'm a proponent of imagining others are smiling, nodding, and loving what you do. You don't have signals to tell you otherwise, so you may as well use this opportunity to boost your confidence while presenting!

When you are actively watching others in the room, sometimes you can catch a specific moment when attitudes change: a general relaxing of demeanors (a good thing) or a stiffening (not usually such a good thing but still a useful signal). Consider how to use this information. With less positive responses, should you do anything to address them, do something differently to keep from making it worse, or simply continue to push forward in hopes that you'll bring them around? On the brighter side, if hearts have just warmed or credibility was gained, is that enough to carry you through, or will you lean into the actions or words that helped you make it happen?

Speaking of leaning: that's another way to read your audience. As we noted in Chapter 10, leaning in signals interest (unless a hand is aggressively on the table or a finger is out—these typically indicate that the person wants to say something!). Leaning back is a sign of confidence, though read this one carefully, since it can also signal feelings of dislike or negativity (this is a subconscious response; we are naturally inclined to try to distance ourselves from things that are unpleasant) or indifference.

Another sign of indifference—or, taking things a step further, *disinterest*—is when an audience member visibly turns their attention to something else. When someone starts rifling through papers in front of them, opens their laptop and begins to type, or picks up their phone and starts scrolling: you've lost them. Their actions speak loudly. When you observe this happening, you have to decide whether you're going to do anything about it. This obviously depends on the situation and who the person is. Your course of action (or lack thereof) will be different if it is a couple of people in a big presentation compared to a key stakeholder who you need to have engaged.

This is one of the reasons I suggested you stand while presenting. It affords you some effective tricks. To address the disengaged stakeholder, walking to near where they are seated and continuing to talk from there can sometimes lead to a laptop being shut or phone being set down. It's uncomfortable for an individual to be focused on something else when they know that you—the speaker—are close and that all eyes are looking in that direction.

Podium pet peeves

While I generally like to teach by framing things positively—proactive things you can do to improve or be more effective—sharing what doesn't work well also lends insight. You want to connect with your audience. Don't let potential irritations impair your ability to do so. With that in mind, here are some of my personal presenter pet peeves.

Please *don't*...

- **Start with “Can you hear me?”** Work this out ahead of time.
- **Now that we've established the microphone is working...use it poorly.** Your audience doesn't want to listen to your p's popping, but they do want to hear you clearly. When using a handheld mic, this generally means holding it close to, but not touching, your mouth. Test and adjust hands-free microphones before you start to ensure they don't rub noisily against clothing or hair.
- **Stand behind the podium.** Don't let a physical barrier come between you and others! Step out from behind the podium (or rearrange the furniture ahead of time to remove obstacles in your way). Don't let anything block your face. Ensure people have a clear line of sight so they can connect with you.
- **Dishonor your audience.** This can take a variety of forms: making an obscure reference that only a portion of attendees will know or relate to or telling them something generally known as if it were novel are a couple examples. Watch for things you say or do that could be interpreted by your audience to signal that you don't understand them.
- **Call attention to technical difficulties.** Either it wasn't obvious, in which case you've now pointed it out to them, or it was blatant and they were already aware. There's no reason to emphasize the issue.

- **Read your notes.** You cannot connect with others when you do this! It's also a credibility killer because it gives the impression that you aren't comfortable with your content. It's fine to refer to a note now and then (for example, to remind yourself of a specific reference or read a quote), but in general, avoid reading from notes or slides.
- **Make self-deprecating comments.** Your audience would like to be confident in you. If you aren't self-assured, that makes it difficult for them.
- **End with "That's it" or "That's what I have for you."** As we discussed in Chapter 9, plan a powerful close, reinforcing salient points and leaving people inspired and ready to act.

There are additional actions you can take (particularly if the disengagement you've observed is with more than a tiny fraction of those in attendance). Use your voice—or lack of voice. If you've been talking, talking, talking...

Simply...stop.

The shift from constant chatter to silence is attention garnering. The other means of audible contrast that we discussed in Chapter 10 can also be used: slow down, speed up, make a point **LOUDLY** to get people to tune in. Use your hands in a grand gesture. Run into the audience!

Connect with people

Well, okay, probably don't run into the audience. Though I have actually done something similar before—I *stepped off* of the stage into the crowd during a large conference presentation. It wasn't to get others to engage; they were already paying attention. I had been building to a crescendo and wanted

to impart this pivotal moment in the same physical space with everyone. This broke the invisible barrier in an interesting way. And it meant I could really see faces, make eye contact, and connect.

I brought my audience into my presentation by going to them. Another way to relate is to bring them (figuratively) to you: invite interaction. This can take many different forms and will vary widely depending on your situation. It might be handled via questions addressed in the moment or discussion that happens over the course of your meeting. Encourage people to shout out short responses in a large group or have a microphone runner who helps amplify voices and ideas. You can integrate interactive polls or invite attendees to share thoughts via chat in your virtual presentation. Look for ways to include your audience—they will be more engaged and attentive. In the event that decisions are being made, they will be more bought in, too.

If someone raises a topic or poses a question that you know you are going to want to redirect to someone else who is present, acknowledge it: “That’s a great question, Sarah! Brian, I’m going to turn to you momentarily so you can let us know your thoughts. Before I do that, I’ll tell you my immediate reaction.” This is especially effective in a virtual setting, where it’s possible that Brian got distracted by his email. Calling him out by name and warning him that you’re turning things over to him soon gets his attention back and provides him a moment to collect his thoughts.

I’ve framed this instance as having a more intimate setting, where you know the individuals. A variation of this works in other scenarios as well. Imagine a workshop setting where someone poses a question that I want to use to invite additional interaction. I could respond with something like, “Great point. I’d like to hear some experiences from the group. First, I’ll share one that comes to my mind....” This gives people the time both to think about whether they have something to contribute and to gather their courage to speak up. Or if I want to give *myself* some time to think, I can flip this around: “That’s an excellent question. Before I lend my thoughts, I’m going to open it up to the room—what do others think?”

Addressing questions

I've mentioned one strategy I sometimes use when facing questions. I've also been known to respond to off-the-wall questions with a redirect. "That's an interesting thought. Another question people commonly have about this topic is...." That won't always be appropriate, but it is another trick to have up your sleeve as you try to maintain order when fielding queries. For more tips and strategies related to handling Q&A sessions and eloquently responding to questions in general, check out the *storytelling with data* podcast Episode 46, "questions about questions" (storytellingwithdata.com/podcast).

Respond gracefully to the unexpected

I've seen Murphy's Law play out time after time in my own meetings, workshops, and presentations: if anything can go wrong, it will. While this may seem like a pessimistic observation, I don't view it that way. I appreciate the unexpected things that arise—these are instances that help keep me in the moment, on my toes, and learning.

While you might be totally flustered on the inside while trying to figure out how to handle the situation, magic is created when you project calmness—in spite of the troubles—to others. Further, if you *look* composed, it helps you start to feel that way, too. Take a deep breath, then consider a feasible course of action. Here are some tactics I've used over time:

- **Smile, recognize it, and move on.** I once fully tripped on a cord while on stage. In one moment, I was walking and talking; in the following, I was flat on the floor, handheld microphone bouncing loudly across the stage. What to do?! I took a moment to try to regain my composure (impossible on the inside, but I deliberately put on a brave face), stood up, took the

microphone from the nice man who grabbed it for me, and paused. I took a deep breath, smiled at my audience, and said sarcastically, “You’ve just witnessed my impeccable grace.” Then I resumed my presentation from where I left off. (This is the primary reason I now have blue tape in my presenter pack—my heels won’t catch on cords that are properly taped down!)

- **Solicit help.** Midway through an important meeting, my computer crashed and refused to come back to life. Fortunately, one of my colleagues was also in attendance. I borrowed his computer and asked him to take control of the room by facilitating an impromptu discussion while I downloaded my slides (which were luckily saved to the cloud) until I was ready to resume.
- **Change your plans.** On an occasion that I touched upon previously, I was about to start a workshop but was having trouble getting the projector to work. Several others tried to help without success. The AV guy—who was apparently the only one who knew how to run it—wasn’t available, so it was clear I would have to begin the session without my slides. This highlights another great reason to arrive early. In the minutes before start time, I was able to reorganize my content, starting with a topic that didn’t rely heavily on slides and drawing on the whiteboard when visual aid was crucial. When tech support finally arrived, we took a break and got the slides up and running for the rest of the session.
- **Improvise.** In another instance, I was preparing to facilitate an interactive off-site session for a group of 100. The multi-page handouts I had emailed ahead of time to be printed for the day that contained our hands-on exercises had been forgotten at the office 60 miles away. I sent one of the organizers to the nearby copy and print store with the handouts on a thumb drive, another to locate blank paper to pass out to attendees, and then set to work creating additional slides to direct the hands-on activities until the hard copies arrived.
- **Provide another solution.** In a virtual training session, we once encountered tech issues that prevented some participants from joining until halfway through the hour. To make up for it, we offered them a spot in a future session and also provided video content that covered the concepts that were missed.

- **Reschedule.** There are times when the session simply can't go on as planned. We can't control or fix everything. A critical stakeholder can't attend, the video conferencing application has an outage, the power goes out. In these extreme cases, rescheduling may be the best option.

When things do go awry, don't dwell on it. Also try not to let it impact the rest of your session.

The unexpected comes in many flavors. I've shared some anecdotes of things gone wrong, but there are also instances where the scenario simply isn't what you anticipated. For example, you're planning to start your keynote presentation by introducing yourself, then the person who you thought was simply going to say your name and hand you the microphone gives a full rundown of your background before doing so. Ideally, you'll know ahead of time whether to expect this. Otherwise, you need to think on your feet and decide how to respond. You might skip your intro altogether and jump straight into content. Or make the succession of events appear purposeful with an additive statement: "That was a great overview. I do want to tell you a little more about myself, but I'm going to do it in a different way..." (and then launch into the story of you as you intended).

As another case of things going a little differently than planned, I was once getting ready to deliver a keynote session. Directly before I went on stage, the organizer asked everyone to get out their phone to take a picture of a QR code that was projected on the screen and complete a brief survey. *Aargh!* The *last* thing I wanted to do was begin my presentation while everyone was distracted on their phone. I had to determine quickly how to get their attention back. I walked out onto the stage and stood dead center, silent. I looked out at the audience, smiling, for what was probably an awkward amount of time. But it worked. Phones were put away and eyes were directed to me. When I launched in with my powerful planned start, I had their full attention.

These situations—and others like them—can cause some discomfort. You may experience bad feelings simply reading about them or thinking about the various aspects of your own presentations that could take unexpected turns. I like

to think of this as *productive discomfort*. If you can get comfortable being a little uncomfortable, you will be able to respond to any scenario that arises (or at least the majority of them!) with eloquence.

Embrace the unexpected. It's when some of your most transformational presentation moments will happen.

Time to reflect—and refine for next time!

You did it: you were present in the moment, you watched your audience and adjusted, you connected with people, and you responded elegantly to the unexpected. You are finished giving your presentation!

The hard work is complete, but you are not done. There isn't an end point to being a skilled presenter. Every presentation is another opportunity to try something new, learn, and improve.

After your session is over, take a few moments to reflect. Did the things you hoped would take place happen? Look back at the goals you outlined for yourself ahead of time. Were you successful? What learnings or refinements will you pull forward into forthcoming presentations? Connect with the person you identified to give you feedback. See whether and how this changes your perception and goals. Set your plan for your next presentation. And then do it all again!

As you think about the future, let's take one final look back—to the case study we've been working our way through.

Have a stellar session: TRIX case study

You've accompanied me along quite a journey as I planned, created, and prepared to deliver my presentation to the client team at Nosh. As I write these words, that final presentation is already behind me. Months of analysis, followed by weeks of preparation—all that work culminated in a single critical hour that felt like it flew by in an instant.

How did the meeting go? I'll let you judge for yourself. Watch it at storytellingwithyou.com/finale. You can also view my slide deck on the following pages.

My final words to you (for now) as you plan, create, and deliver: strive to continually refine and improve. Here's to your next presentation. Make it a stellar one!